

Armenia

Competition Protection Commission

The Competition Protection Commission (hereinafter referred to as ‘the Commission’) of the Republic of Armenia is an autonomous competition authority that was established in 2001 under the Law on Protection of Economic Competition. The primary objective of the Commission is to ensure the freedom of economic activity, free economic competition, fair competition, and the necessary environment for entrepreneurship development, also entrusted with the function of protecting consumer interests.

In 2021 the Commission started to fundamentally reshape the activities from traditional to electronic by developing an electronic platform that would streamline its internal and external documentation and offer access to different state platforms.

As of March 2022, the electronic platform has been successfully launched. The electronic platform that is called “e-Compete” consists of an official interactive website and an internal case management system, the mutual integration of which enables to collect information from external sources and transfer them to the internal system, as well as to automatically publish information deriving from internal procedures on the Commission's website.

With various full-fledged instruments, the platform allows analyzing and comparing relevant markets, controlling transactions made by legal entities in order to identify undeclared concentrations, controlling the implementation of the Commission's decisions, monitoring prices for a number of goods on a daily basis, etc.

The platform's core operational systems are outlined below, showcasing its robust capabilities and advanced features.

I. Interoperability with electronic platforms of other state institutions

- The electronic platform offers access to a number of state institutions platforms, such as the state revenue committee, cadaster committee, state register of legal entities, etc. This advanced feature has enabled the

Commission to seamlessly integrate its operations with other state entities, resulting in a more streamlined and efficient regulatory process.

- Through web services the Commission receives different kind of information, such as: shareholders of the legal entity, participation in other companies, group of persons, areas of activity, amounts of assets and revenues or personal information about physical persons, etc.
- The algorithms auto-analyze datasets on legal entities from different state authorities, and flag transactions that are most likely to contain possible violations of the law in the context of merger control.

II. E-filing and registration in the Commission's electronic platform

- Stakeholders can now easily register and submit their documents to the Commission electronically, in a matter of clicks, through the e-filing system eliminating the need for physical submission processes. This has effectively minimized the time and costs associated with traditional paper-based processes, making it a more efficient and cost-effective option for all stakeholders involved.
- The electronic platform fully digitized the Commission's internal document flow and processing, spanning from the initiation of the administrative proceedings to the crucial decision-making process, as well as appeals.
- All templates of documents for submitting to the Commission are available in the system in electronic forms, and submission of documents is simplified and does not require electronic signature. Moreover, the process of document submission has been streamlined and simplified to such an extent that electronic signatures are no longer necessary, making it easier than ever for stakeholders to submit their documents in a timely manner.
- All decisions made by the Commission have been digitized, and the electronic platform generates statistical reports based on the data of these decisions.

III. Monitoring of prices for everyday transactions with platform algorithms

- The electronic platform provides an efficient and effective monitoring of the prices of selected goods. Namely, the Commission has access to the prices of goods and services collected daily from the databases of State Revenue

Committee, which allows it to closely track and analyze the prices of various goods in real-time.

- The platform's algorithms enable the Commission to monitor changes in prices and detect any instances of price fixing or other anticompetitive behavior.
- The Commission automatically publishes information on its website, providing transparency and accessibility to the public.
- Consumers can easily access this information by selecting the specific type of goods they are interested in or searching for a specific seller.
- To conclude, although human analysis remains an indispensable component of our daily processes, the implementation of the electronic platform has vastly improved the Commission's monitoring capabilities, enabling us to swiftly and efficiently identify potential instances of anticompetitive behavior. The Commission remains committed to exploring and leveraging cutting-edge computational tools in its daily processes firmly believing that by embracing the latest technological advancements, we can better safeguard fair competition and promote the interests of consumers, paving the way for a more equitable and prosperous future.